Jains in Tamil Nadu

There is a clear evidence of the movements of the Jains from Karnataka to the Kongu region (Salem, Erode and Coimbatore areas), to the Kaveri Delta (Tiruchirapalli) southwards into Pudukkottai region (Sittannavasal) and finally into the Pandya kingdom (Madurai, Ramanathapuram and Tirunelveli districts). Tamils broadly come under *Digambara* sect. It is believed that the Kalabhras were the patrons of Jainism.

The Sittanavasal Cave Temple

Sittanavasal cave in Pudukkottai district is located on a prominent rock that stands 70 m above the ground. It has a natural cavern, known as Eladipattam, at one end, and a rock-cut cave temple at the other. Behind the fenced cavern, there are 17 rock beds marked on the floor. The stone berths aligned in rows are believed to have served as a Jain shelter. The largest of these ascetic beds contains a Tamil-Brahmi inscription that dates to the 2nd century BC (BCE) There are more inscriptions in Tamil from the 8th century AD (CE) bearing the names of monks. It is believed that they should have spent their lives in isolation here.



Sittanavasal Cave

The Sittanavasal cave temple, named Arivar Koil, lies on the west off the hillock. The facade of the temple is simple, with four rock-cut columns. Constructed in the early Pandya period, in the 7th century AD (CE) it has a hall in the front called the Ardha-mandapam and a smaller cell at the rear, which is the *garbha graha* (sanctum sanctorum).



Fresco Paintings, Sittanavasal

The murals in the temple resemble the frescoes of the famous Ajanta caves. The Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) took over the caves only in 1958. Thereafter it took two decades to cover the cave and regulate the entry of visitors. There are the bas- relief figures of Tirthankaras on the left wall of the hall and acharyas on the right before one enters the inner chamber, the sanctum sanctorum.

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